

SECRET BOMBING OF CAMBODIA: ABC's OF A GROWING DISPUTE

JUST AS the U.S. military role in Southeast Asia seemed to be closing out at last, new controversy boiled up over one aspect of the Vietnam war.

The issue: secret bombing raids launched by the U.S. in 1969 and 1970 into supposedly neutral Cambodia.

In the Senate, an investigation of the bombing—and an attempt to discover who was responsible for keeping it secret—was being carried out. Administration officials were embarrassed by charges that false records were kept of the bombing, that Congressmen in posts of power were not kept fully informed of the raids.

On some key points—

Just what happened in Cambodia?

Between March, 1969, and May, 1970, U.S. B-52 bombers flew 3,630 sorties into Cambodia, dropping 104,000 tons of bombs on the positions of North Vietnamese who were using that country as a storage depot and supply route into South Vietnam.

These attacks were not announced publicly at the time—or subsequently. High officials at the Pentagon, both military and civilian, were kept in the dark. Spokesmen say that only a few Congressmen were told of the raids. Generally, they were ones regarded as sympathetic to White House war aims.

Why should bombing of North Vietnamese bases have been a secret operation?

It is necessary to remember that this took place before Mr. Nixon ordered the open “incursion” into Cambodia in May, 1970, to destroy enemy “sanctuaries.” The Administration’s position is that Prince Norodom Sihanouk, the head of the Cambodian Government, unofficially agreed to the raids as long as they were not made public and did not endanger Cambodian citizens.

Sihanouk was a “neutral.” He had ties with Hanoi and with Communist China. When he was later ousted, Sihanouk went to live in Peking, and is now identified with the Communist forces in Cambodia.

Administration officials insist that Sihanouk would have been forced to protest the bombings, if they had been made public, or else risk his country’s relations with North Vietnam.

The Prince recently denied that he approved any such raids.

What was the Administration’s justification for the raids?

The same justification stated by Mr. Nixon for the Cambodian “incursion”—to save American lives in South Vietnam and to speed up the U.S. withdrawal. The argument is made that the President had the authority to order bombing in Southeast Asia to protect the safety of U.S. troops.

Military spokesmen contend that some success was achieved by the raids—that U.S. casualties in Vietnam did show a downward trend because of them.

How could such heavy bombing, over

want to lose the opportunity to conduct these operations.”

Some Congressmen point out that President Nixon didn’t mention the bombings when he announced, in a nationwide television address on April 30, 1970, that the U.S. was taking military action in Cambodia.

Mr. Nixon noted in that speech that Cambodia had been “a neutral nation since the Geneva Agreement of 1954,” and added:

“American policy since then has been



U.S. bombs falling on Cambodia in July, 1973. In 1969-70, it is now disclosed, similar air raids were made secretly against North Vietnamese bases in that “neutralist” country.

a period of 14 months, be kept secret from most of official Washington?

The Pentagon acknowledges that two sets of books were kept. The bombs dropped on Cambodia were simply listed as having been dropped in South Vietnam. Reports sent to Congress in 1973—three years after the secret raids had ended—still failed to mention any bombing of Cambodia during the 14 months.

Jerry W. Friedheim, the Pentagon spokesman, explains it this way—

“It’s not a question of trying to set up a system that would falsify records; it was a question of setting up a special reporting procedure. We didn’t

to scrupulously respect the neutrality of the Cambodian people.”

Just what was the President’s role in the clandestine raids?

Melvin Laird, who was then the Secretary of Defense, says he recommended the secret bombings to Mr. Nixon after a visit to South Vietnam.

Gen. Earle G. Wheeler, retired Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, sat in on White House conferences that led to the bombing decision. He told a Senate committee on July 30 that Mr. Nixon had personally ordered the raids to be carried out under the tightest security. Said the General:

“His instructions were of a general

nature, but very emphatic. He wanted the matter held with the greatest secrecy." General Wheeler added that later he received a letter from the President "congratulating me for the good job of maintaining secrecy."

One of the high officials not told of the raids was Robert C. Seamans, Jr., Secretary of the Air Force until recently. He told the Senate Committee:

"I would have been more helpful to the Air Force and to the country if I had been better informed. Certainly I, as Secretary of the Air Force, don't like to be in a position of having supplied inaccurate information to the Congress, which is what I did."

How did this undercover operation finally become a matter of record?

On July 16, an Air Force officer, Maj. Hal M. Knight, Jr., testified before the Senate Armed Forces Committee that, under orders, his radar crew guided B-52 bombers to Cambodian targets. Further, he said, he was told by his superiors to prepare false bombing reports showing that the raids occurred over South Vietnam. He also testified that, under orders, he burned the true documents about the raids.

Wasn't Cambodia still being bombed in the summer of 1973?

Yes, at the request of the present Cambodian Government, according to the Administration. But, under an amendment added to a military appropriations bill by Congress—and signed into law by Mr. Nixon—the bombing was to halt by August 15.

Has the bombing and the accompanying secrecy led to any specific action in Congress against the President?

Representative Robert F. Drinan (Dem.), of Massachusetts, introduced impeachment proceedings in the House on July 31, specifically citing the "totally secret air war in Cambodia." The matter was referred to the House Judiciary Committee, but it drew no immediate support from House leaders.

What's really at issue between Congress and the Administration?

Here are reactions from two Senators who conducted hearings on the raids—

Senator Harold Hughes (Dem.), of Iowa, said: "Official deceit and secret warfare are more ominous than any problem confronting our country."

Senator Stuart Symington (Dem.), of Missouri, acting chairman of the Armed Services Committee, said funds spent on the secret bombing "must have been obtained under what could be known as false pretenses." He added:

"By giving the Committee false information, they never gave us a chance to authorize the money for the use they made of it. . . . This is clearly unconstitutional."

[END]

She needs your love.



CHRISTIAN CHILDREN'S FUND, INC.
BELO HORIZONTE, BRAZIL
CASEWORKER REPORT



TO FAMILY HELPER PROJECT, SAO DOMINGOS

NAME: MARTA MARIA DA SYLVA

AGE: 4½ YEARS

NATIVE PLACE: BELO HORIZONTE

ORDER OF BIRTH: LAST CHILD (LIVING)

HEALTH: FAIR, VITAMIN DEPRIVED WITH POSSIBLE DAMAGE TO HER EYESIGHT. CUTS AND BRUISES ON BACK & LEGS.

CHARACTERISTICS: CHEERFUL, BRIGHT, AFFECTIONATE, SPEAKS WITH SLIGHT LISP.

PARENTS CONDITION: FATHER: BLIND, ASKS ALMS ON THE STREETS.
MOTHER: DECEASED, DIED IN CHILDBIRTH (INFANT STILLBORN).

INVESTIGATION REPORT:
MARTA'S FATHER SUFFERED FROM AN ILLNESS SEVERAL YEARS AGO WHICH LEFT HIM BLIND. HE CAN GET ONLY A FEW PENNIES A DAY FROM BEGGING. HE CANNOT TAKE CARE OF, OR PROTECT HIS CHILDREN. HOME SITUATION BAD. THERE IS LIVING WITH THE FAMILY AN "UNCLE" WHO IS CRUEL AND IS SUSPECTED OF TAKING ADVANTAGE OF, AND BEATING THE BOYS (MARTA'S OLDER BROTHERS). SO FAR ONLY MARTA, FATHER PITIFUL IN HIS PLEA THAT WE HELP MARTA. HE IS TERRIFIED AT WHAT MAY BECOME OF HER. BEGS US TO HELP SO THEY CAN MOVE AWAY FROM UNCLE'S HOUSE. (HUT APPEARS TO BELONG TO THIS "UNCLE.")

HOME CONDITIONS:
HOUSE: TWO ROOM HUT OCCUPIED BY MARTA, HER TWO BROTHERS, HER FATHER AND A MAN THEY CALL UNCLE BUT WHOSE ACTUAL RELATIONSHIP TO THE FAMILY IS NOT CLEAR. THE "UNCLE" IS A BRUTAL MAN AND IT APPEARS LIKELY HIS "PUNISHMENTS" ACCOUNT FOR THE BRUISES & CUTS ON MARTA. FATHER FEARS THE UNCLE BUT BEING BLIND IS UNABLE TO DO ANYTHING. HOUSE IS DIRTY - NO SANITATION OR RUNNING WATER.

BROTHERS: ALIMIRO FELIX DA SYLVA - AGE 8 YEARS
ANTONIO ADRIANO DA SYLVA - AGE 7 YEARS

REMARKS: IN SPITE OF BAD HOME LIFE, MARTA IS A TRUSTING, SWEET CHILD. BUT SOON SHE MUST CHANGE IF HELP DOESN'T COME. FATHER IS EAGERLY WILLING TO COOPERATE IN ALL WAYS IF CCF CAN FIND SPONSOR FOR MARTA AND ENROLL HER IN FHP PROGRAM.

URGENT: RECOMMEND IMMEDIATE ACCEPTANCE INTO CCF SAO DOMINGOS FHP.

Every day our workers around the world receive reports like this one on Marta (her real name is not used to protect her future).

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For only \$12 a month you can sponsor a child like Marta. Just fill out the coupon and mail it with your first monthly check. In about two weeks you will receive a photo and personal history of the child you are helping.

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